



Course Title: Loss, Grief, and Bereavement

Course Number: NURS 5110

Semester: Spring 2026

Credit: One credit unit

Catalogue Description: Loss, grief, and bereavement are pervasive aspects of the human experience. The content of this course provides a basis both for personal development and professional growth. Through a series of seminars, key issues surrounding loss, death, dying, grief, and bereavement will be examined.

Canvas Page: <https://canvas.upenn.edu/courses/1888738>

Faculty Contact Information, and Office Hours:

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Office hours: Mondays at noon and other times, with prior confirmation.

Objectives:

At the conclusion of this course, the learner will be able to:

- 1- Articulate the importance of having a theoretical framework with which to understand the complexities of human response to loss, grief, and bereavement, and to intervene effectively in the clinical setting.
- 2- Recognize the influence of their own well-being and response to loss and death on clinical practice.
- 3- More fully understand how the many different circumstances around loss and death influence patients' and families' responses.
- 4- Understand how current evidence about bereavement informs practice with grieving individuals and families in acute care and community settings.

Teaching Methods: Seminar discussion with guest experts. In-class discussions. Lectures. Application of knowledge as evidenced by assignment completion.

Statement of Welcome, Respect, Belonging, and Community:

Penn Nursing is committed to a learning environment that celebrates us all as individuals and as a community, respecting our identities and diversity. Dimensions of diversity include but are not limited to sex, race, age, national origin, ethnicity, gender identity and expression, intellectual and physical abilities, sexual orientation, income, faith and spirituality, socio-economic class, political ideology, education, primary language, family status, military experience, cognitive style, and communication style. We expect every member of our classroom community to contribute to an inclusive and respectful culture. The individual intersection of experiences and characteristics are valued in our classroom. We support every student in every classroom, whether in-person or on a virtual platform, to find and embrace the ability to speak up and participate. Because we thrive on the diversity of everyone's beliefs,

backgrounds, and experiences, we expect that each member of this class is ensured respect, fairness, and equality consistent with our mission, values, and guiding principles. In that way, we affirm that we are an inclusive community who value our universality and our diversity. As such, we are curious, empathic, and supportive of one another, of our fellow people, and of the planet. We hold awareness of ourselves and other beings as central to our work as nurses. We acknowledge our limitations and seek to expand on them, taking responsibility when we misstep or make mistakes. With active hope, we join with one another in learning, in care, and in commitment.

Academic Integrity:

Academic Integrity is foundational to this course. [The International Center for Academic Integrity](#) states that 'Academic integrity is a commitment, even in the face of adversity, to six fundamental values: honesty, trust, fairness, respect, responsibility, and courage. From these values flow principles of behavior that enable academic communities to translate ideals into action.' Adherence to the [University of Pennsylvania Code of Academic Integrity](#) is required of every student in all coursework and all course interactions. Please refer to Penn Nursing guidance on [University of Pennsylvania Student Policies](#).

Course Policies

Attendance

- Class attendance is expected.
- All absences are required to be communicated to the instructor via email at least two hours before the start of class. Excusal of the absence will be at the instructor's discretion.
- A compensatory assignment will be required for approved and non-approved absences.

Zoom etiquette

- Participation from a private location is required for synchronous sessions. The course covers sensitive material, and a secure environment for all participants is a priority.
- The video feed must be on during synchronous sessions, and the participant must be visible. If you are unable to meet this requirement (e.g., due to illness) notify the instructor that you will be absent, according to the attendance instructions.

Social Media

Adherence to the School of Nursing's Social Media policy is required: [Student-social-media-policy](#)

Grading

Evaluation Methods:

1. Course Engagement and Operations 7.5%
2. Discussion Boards 12.5%
3. Documentary of Choice 12.5%
4. Group Project: Further Exploration of Loss and Grief 20%
5. Preparation and Takeaways 30%
6. Reflections 17.5%

Grading Scale:

A+ 97-100	B+ 87-89	C+ 77-79
A 93-96	B 83-86	C 73-76
A- 90-92	B- 80-82	C- 70-72

A. Final Course Letter Grade Computation:

All course grades will be rounded to the nearest percentage point when assigning the letter grade (e.g., 96.5 is a 97/A+, 96.4 is a 96/A)

B. Late Assignment Submissions

A deduction of 10% per day will be made for submissions made any time after the deadline on Canvas. One assignment during the semester may be submitted up to three days late without penalty, with a minimum of 48 hours prior email notice to the course director. *Exceptions; discussion boards, group project, final reflection.*

Required Readings:

- Walsh, K. (2022). *Grief and loss: Theories and skills for the helping professions* (3rd edition). Waveland Press, Inc.
- Additional materials are on Canvas.

Topical Outline

Week 1: Course Introduction. Self-Preparation in the Helping Professions.

Week 2: Grief, Mourning, and Bereavement. Cultural Humility.

Week 3: Children and Adolescents

Week 4: Perinatal Loss

Week 5: Older Adults

Week 6: Young and Middle Adulthood

Week 7: Stories of Transformation. Remembrances and Memorials.

Week 8: Traumatic Loss. Prolonged Grief. Arts and Healing.

Week 9: Palliative Care

Week 10: Military Veterans and Families. Communal Loss. Loss Related to Suicide

Week 11 Documentary of Choice. Project preparation.

Week 12: Dialogue with a Chaplain

Week 13 Group Project Presentations. Holidays and Loss

Week 14 Group Project Presentations. Course Closing